

CRESTED PORCUPINE

Hystrix cristata

With its long, barbed quills raised in threat, the crested porcupine is an intimidating prospect. A predator that has had the painful experience of being spiked is unlikely ever to attempt another attack. Lions, hyenas, and even people have been known to die from infected quill injuries. Despite this impressive means of defence, the porcupine is a peaceable and rather nervous animal, easily startled, and more likely to flee danger than stand its ground. Porcupines live alone or in family groups, sharing extensive burrow systems. Crested porcupines occur throughout much of northern Africa. The species was also once widespread in southern Europe – the population found in Italy may be a relic of former times or the result of a more recent introduction, perhaps by the Romans.



SIZE 45–93 cm (18–36½ in)

HABITAT Savanna grassland, light woodland, rocky terrain

DISTRIBUTION Northern Africa as far south as Tanzania, except Sahara Desert; also Italy

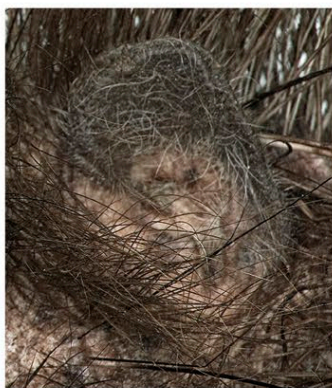
DIET Mainly roots, fruits, and tubers; occasionally carrion

< SPIKY HAIR-DO

Raising the quills creates an illusion of size. A cornered porcupine will stand tall and try to bluff its way out of trouble. If this fails, it will turn tail and charge backwards, shoving its spiky rear end in the face of its attacker.

EAR >

The small ears are largely hidden in the coarse hair. The porcupine has good hearing, which it uses to avoid danger, shuffling off into the night if it hears another animal approaching.



✓ EYE

A porcupine's eyesight is poor, but then there is often little to see in the darkness of an African night. It uses its sharp senses of hearing and smell to find its way.



✓ MOUTH AND TEETH

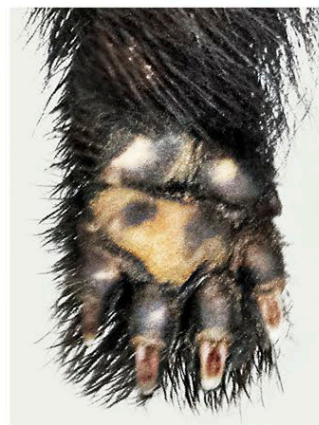
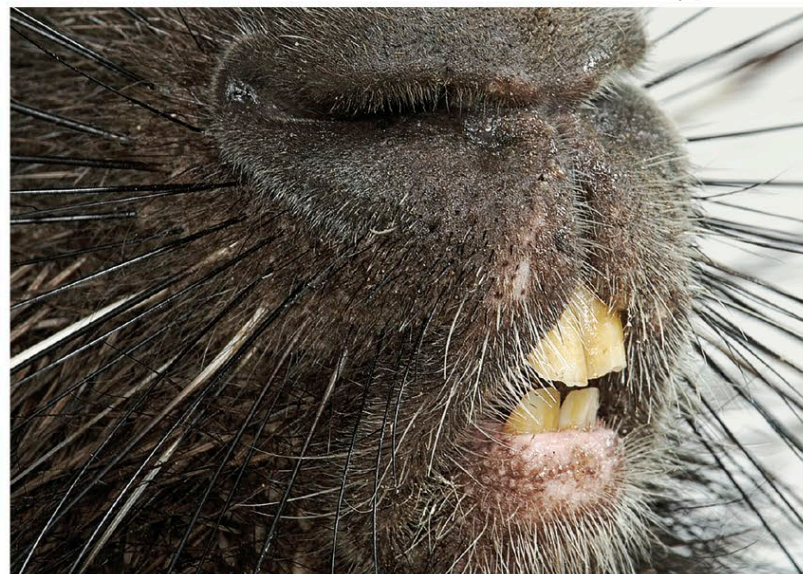
Porcupines have the specialized gnawing teeth typical of rodents, enabling them to chew tough roots and tubers. The muscles that control the jaws are immensely powerful.

QUILLS-A-QUIVER >

Porcupine quills are greatly enlarged hairs. They can be raised by larger versions of the tiny muscles that create goosebumps in our own skin.



like its quills, the porcupine's thin coat of coarse hair can also be raised in alarm



RATTLING TAIL ^

The quills of the tail are swollen and hollow. The porcupine shakes them when alarmed and the soft rattling sound warns its enemies that this is a well-armed opponent.

< ^ FEET AND CLAWS

Porcupines walk on the flat soles of their feet, with a slightly clumsy, shambling gait. The soles are hairless and padded. They have short toes and strong claws, well suited to digging.